HEIRSTONE CONSULTING

DIASPORA AND HERITAGE TRAVEL IN AFRICA

The return ticket

What homecoming travel is worth to Africa, how much of it falls in a single season, and what it does to hotels, short lets, heritage towns and coastal property



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ABOUT THIS REPORT

Heirstone Consulting advises developers, investors, tourism authorities and governments across the Middle East and Africa on destinations, hospitality and specialised real estate. This report looks at homecoming travel: trips to Africa by members of the diaspora, whether nationals living abroad or descendants of Africans taken in the Atlantic slave trade, and at what that travel does to beds, seats and land.

It draws on public sources current in 2026: tourism authority reports, civil aviation and border statistics, Eurostat air data, fare indicators, short-let platform data, government project registers and press reports. Every figure is referenced in the exhibit sources and the notes. Where we combine published figures to produce a new one, the calculation is shown and labelled Heirstone analysis. Projections and claims are labelled as such.

The report is published alongside *The absent owner*, a separate Heirstone Consulting Research report on diaspora remittances and property buying.

THE REPORT IN FIGURES

79%

of Ghana's growth in international arrivals in 2025 came in December: +14,395 of +18,158 (Heirstone analysis)

46%

of December visitors to Ghana surveyed stayed in a private home; 23% used a hotel

1.7x

December return search fares London to Lagos and London to Accra, against the cheapest month; Ghana's December flights ran 11% above average

11-13%

December's share of a full year's short-let revenue potential in six December-peak markets

16%

of the US$13m December short-let income claimed for Lagos is visible on Airbnb, by our estimate

9.4m

Egyptians living abroad at the 2017 census, a homecoming market alongside Egypt's 19 million international arrivals in 2025

SUMMARY

Homecoming travel to Africa is a repeat market packed into a few weeks a year. Projects that rely on those weeks alone will struggle to pay their way.

The diaspora's return each December, each summer in Morocco or at Eid in Egypt, is a dependable flow; in Morocco it makes up about half of all arrivals. It is also poorly measured and heavily seasonal, and most of it is housed by families. We sized it from official monthly data, air passenger and fare records and short-let platform data across ten markets, and asked what it can and cannot finance.

1 **The best-known figures were projections.**

The 1.5 million visitors and US$1.9bn linked to Ghana's 2019 Year of Return were reported in late 2019 as expectations for the year; in August 2019 AFP had reported a target of 500,000 visitors and US$925m. Ghana's official count for 2025 is 1,306,962 arrivals. We found no official December count for Nigeria.

2 **December carried Ghana's growth in 2025.**

December arrivals rose 11.4% to 141,186 while January to November rose 0.3%, so December supplied 79% of the year's increase. Air data show 19,103 more arrivals than departures in December 2025, and a January outflow of 14,620 after the previous season.

3 **Seats barely move, so fares ration the peak.**

Ghana's international aircraft movements in December 2025 were 11% above the monthly average while air arrivals were 29% above. Lagos added 1.3% more December seats. December search fares from London to Lagos and Accra run about 1.7 times the cheapest month.

4 **Homecomers stay with family first.**

In Ghana's December survey 46% of visitors stayed in a private home, 23% in a hotel and 21% in an Airbnb. 29% were on a first visit and 96% intend to return. They spend GHS 2,455 (about US$236) a day, 2.6 times a heritage-festival visitor, and 39% of it on accommodation.

5 **December is about an eighth of a short-let year.**

In Accra, Lagos, Nairobi, Cape Town and Cape Coast, December brings 11 to 13% of annual short-let revenue potential; occupancy rises by more than a third and nightly rates by 4 to 5% in Accra and Lagos. Realised short-let yields trail long-let yields wherever we could compare them.

6 **Heritage towns lack beds, and policy is turning to residence.**

Cape Coast, beside Ghana's most-visited castle, has 68 tracked short lets. Benin's published project sheets cost twelve tourism projects at FCFA585bn (about US$1.06bn), 51% of it on two Ouidah coast schemes, and since July 2025 Benin has offered a nationality route to Afro-descendants.

WHAT IT MEANS

Tourism authorities

Count nationals living abroad at the border, as Morocco does, and publish December data within weeks, with the survey method.

Airlines and airports

Add peak capacity in the direction of travel: inbound in December, outbound in January.

Developers and investors

Underwrite on January to November and treat December as the upside. Build for long stays as well as the season.

Promoters and heritage towns

Tie events to beds, and sell the January, Easter and July calendars to repeat visitors.

CHAPTER 1

01 Counting the return

Only Morocco counts its diaspora at the border, and only Ghana publishes the monthly data needed to watch it arrive. Elsewhere the size of the market rests on claims.

87%

Ghana's official 2025 arrivals as a share of the 1.5 million visitors reported in 2019 as expected that year (Heirstone analysis)

Homecoming travel is better branded than it is measured. Ghana's Year of Return, launched in Washington in September 2018 to mark 400 years since the first enslaved Africans were brought to Virginia, is the campaign most associated with diaspora tourism in Africa. In late 2019 the tourism minister was reported as saying that up to 1.5 million tourists were expected by the end of the year, with up to US$1.9bn of revenue.

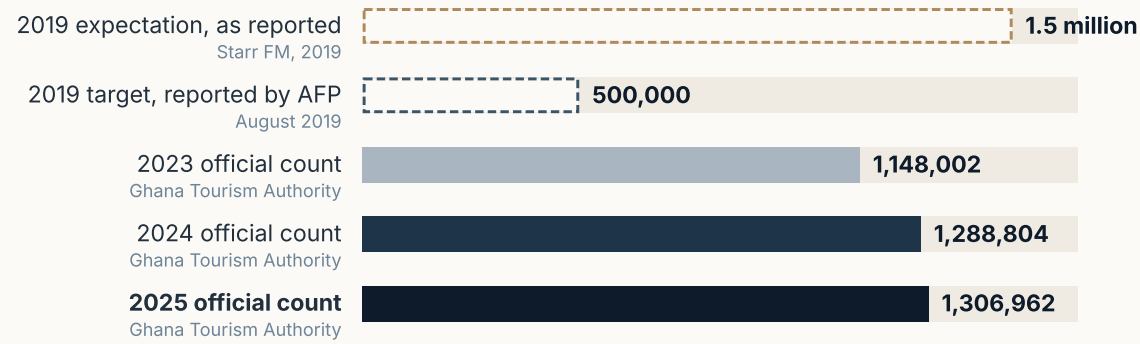
Both figures were expectations for the year, and a deputy tourism minister later said the revenue figure covered the whole tourism sector. In August 2019 AFP reported that Ghana hoped to lift visitors from 350,000 in 2018 to 500,000 in 2019, including 45,000 African Americans, and to earn US$925m. The bases differ, so the AFP figures cannot be set against the official series that followed. The Ghana Tourism Authority (GTA) recorded 1,148,002 international arrivals in 2023, 1,288,804 in 2024 and 1,306,962 in 2025. Six years on, the official count remains below the 1.5 million reported as expected in 2019.

GTA's 2025 report is nonetheless the most useful document on the subject in Africa: monthly arrivals, receipts and surveys of December and heritage-festival visitors. No other market in this report publishes that combination.

EXHIBIT 1

Ghana's official arrivals in 2025 were still below the figure quoted for 2019

International visitors to Ghana: the 2019 projection and target as reported, and official arrivals, 2023 to 2025



Source: Starr FM, Year of Return to rake in 1.9 billion in revenue (2019); Myjoyonline, Deputy Tourism minister clarifies $1.9bn Year of Return revenue (2020); AFP via Yahoo News (23 August 2019); Ghana Tourism Authority, Ghana Tourism Report 2025 (June 2026), Table 1. Dashed bars show projections or targets; the AFP target and the official series use different bases.

WHAT A DECEMBER IS WORTH

By our estimate, Ghana's December season is worth roughly US$0.4bn to US$0.5bn of visitor spending

No country in the set measures what the diaspora spends on a visit. Ghana comes closest. Its international tourism receipts were US$4.34bn in 2025, down from US$4.82bn in 2024, and receipts per visitor fell 11.3% to US$3,319.90 while arrivals rose 1.4%. GTA does not explain the fall, and it should be understood before anyone builds a forecast on the 2024 level.

We sized the Ghanaian December two ways (Heirstone analysis). Applying the 2025 average receipts per visitor to December's 141,186 arrivals gives about US$469m. Applying the December survey's average daily spend of GHS 2,455 (US$236 at GHS 10.4 to the dollar, 31 December 2025) to the same arrivals over the national average stay of 13 nights gives about US$433m. Both are illustrative. December arrivals include business travellers, and GTA does not publish the survey's sample size or length of stay. Together they suggest a December worth about a tenth of annual receipts, in line with December's 10.8% share of arrivals.

Lagos is the only other city with a published figure, and it is a claim. A report cited in a Lagos State House of Assembly motion in February 2025 put the December 2024 season at US$71.6m: about US$44m to hotels and US$13m to short-term rentals. No visitor count or method was published, and the scopes differ, so the Ghana and Lagos figures cannot be reconciled.

-11.3%

change in Ghana's receipts per international visitor in 2025, to US$3,319.90

US$236

average daily spend of a December visitor to Ghana (GHS 2,455 at GHS 10.4 = US$1)

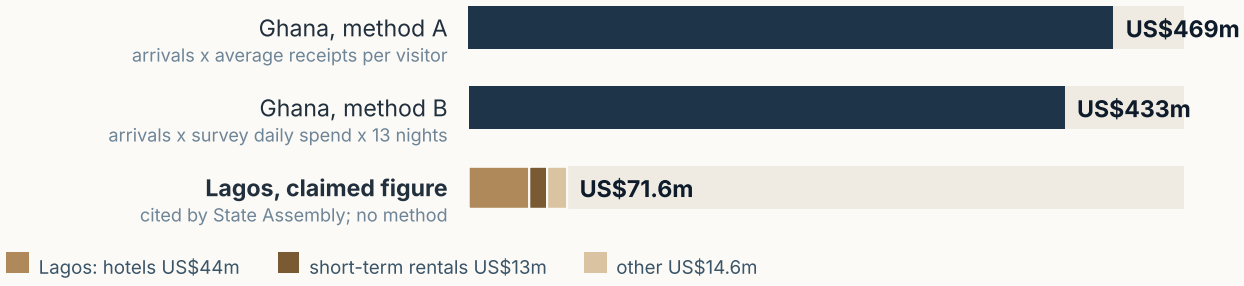
82.6%

of Ghana's 2025 arrivals came through Kotoka International Airport in Accra

EXHIBIT 2

Our two estimates for Ghana's December are about six times the figure claimed for Lagos

Visitor spending attributable to the December season, US$ million: Heirstone estimates for Ghana (December 2025) and the Lagos State figure (December 2024)



Source: Ghana Tourism Authority, Ghana Tourism Report 2025 (June 2026), Tables 1 and 3 and December in GH survey; US Treasury reporting rate GHS 10.4 = US$1 (31 December 2025); ThisDay (15 February 2025). **Heirstone analysis.** A = 141,186 x US$3,319.90. B = 141,186 x GHS 2,455 / 10.4 × 13 nights. Scopes differ; illustrative only.

WHO COUNTS THE DIASPORA

Morocco counts its diaspora at the border. Egypt's 9.4 million nationals abroad form a second market beside its 19 million visitors

Each country counts differently. Morocco is the only country in the set that separates its nationals living abroad, the Marocains résidant à l'étranger (MRE), at the border. In 2024 they made up 49% of 17.4 million arrivals. Morocco's MAD112bn of travel receipts that year works out at about US$637 per arrival, against US$1,466 in Kenya and US$3,320 in Ghana.

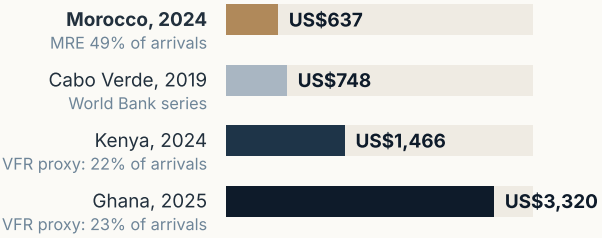
Part of that gap is the diaspora in Morocco's denominator. A family returning to its own home spends far less on accommodation than a foreign tourist. Definitions of receipts also differ by country, so the comparison is indicative.

Egypt's 19 million international arrivals in 2025, up 21% on 2024, count foreign visitors; its nationals abroad form a second market of their own. CAPMAS counted 9.4 million Egyptians living abroad at the 2017 census, a diaspora equal to about half of the 2025 arrivals (Heirstone analysis). Their trips home are not counted separately, so Eid fares and seats, set out in Chapter 6, are the best guide to when they travel. Egyptians abroad also sent home a record US$36.5bn in the 2024/25 fiscal year, according to the Central Bank of Egypt.

EXHIBIT 3

Where the diaspora is counted, receipts per arrival fall

International tourism receipts per arrival, US$, latest available year



Source: Moroccan Ministry of Tourism, key figures 2024; Tourism Research Institute (Kenya), 2024; World Bank WDI (Cabo Verde, 2019); Ghana Tourism Authority, 2025. US Treasury rates at 31 December 2024 (MAD10.103, KES128.85). **Heirstone analysis.** Receipts divided by arrivals. Definitions differ by country.

Ghana and Kenya fall between the two. Neither separates its nationals living abroad; both report visits to friends and relatives (VFR), which made up 23% of Ghana's arrivals in 2025 and 22% of Kenya's in 2024. VFR is a weak proxy for the diaspora. It includes foreigners visiting friends and leaves out nationals who come home on business.

49%
of Morocco's 17.4 million arrivals in 2024 were Moroccans living abroad

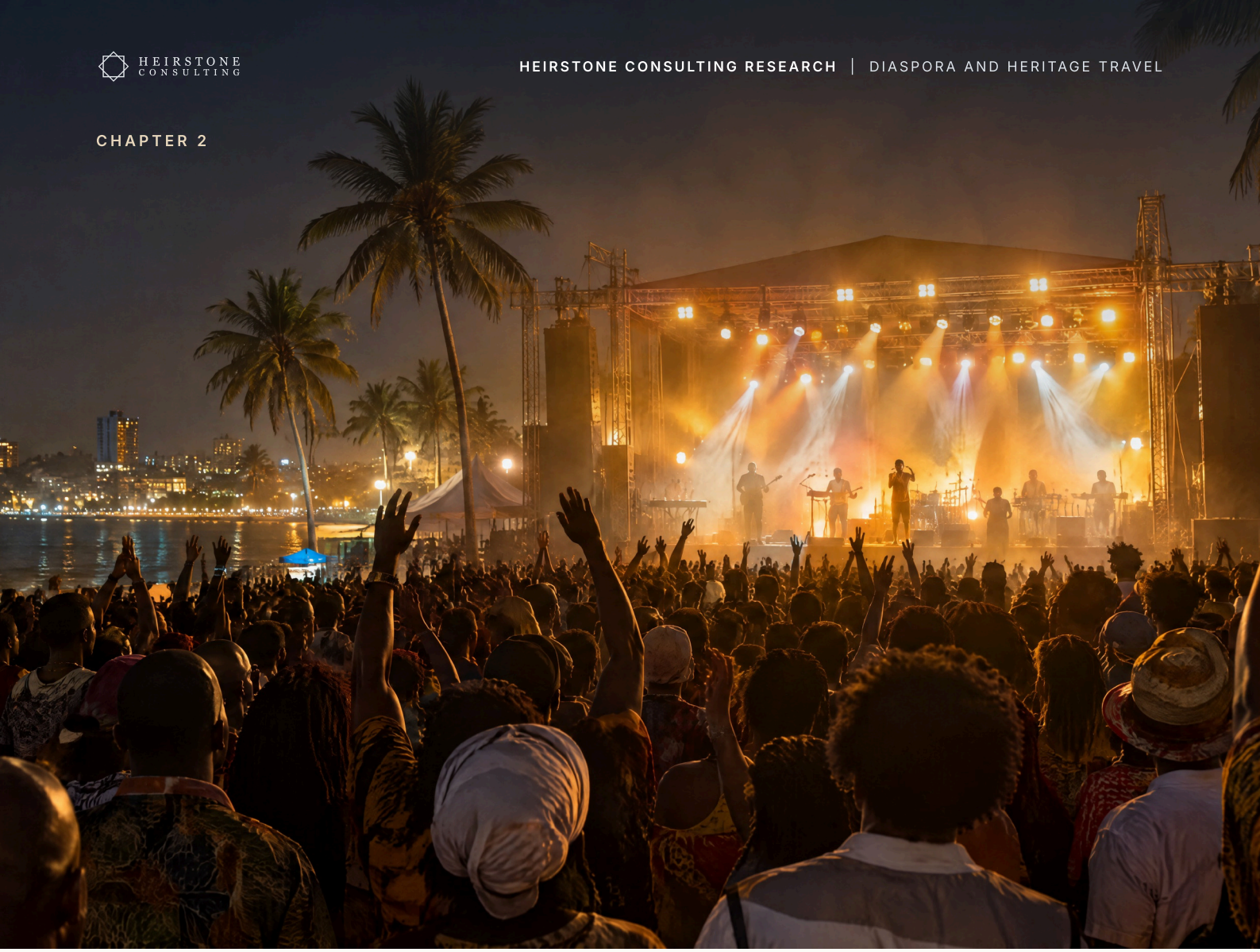
9.4m
Egyptians living abroad at the 2017 census, according to CAPMAS

+21%
growth in Egypt's international arrivals in 2025, to 19 million

US$36.5bn
record remittances from Egyptians abroad in the 2024/25 fiscal year (Central Bank of Egypt)

> *Where nationals living abroad are counted at the border, as in Morocco, they make up about half of all arrivals.*

CHAPTER 2



02

One month carries the year

Accra and Lagos in late December: concerts, weddings, family gatherings and the return of those who left. The season now has a name and, in Ghana, its own visa arrangements.

December in Accra and Lagos has become a season with a brand. The term Detty December is credited to a 2016 Lagos concert hashtag, and the promoter Livespot360 trademarked it in 2019, according to press reports. Ghana's version, marketed by the Ghana Tourism Authority as December in GH since 2019, runs through the festive weeks around concerts, family events and the Christmas return of Ghanaians abroad.

Ghana has opened a visa-on-arrival window over the festive weeks each year since 2022. In 2024 it ran for 46 days without pre-approval, from 1 December 2024 to 15 January 2025.

The season is real, and in 2025 it was the main source of Ghana's growth. It is smaller in volume than its reputation and tightly concentrated in time, and that concentration is what anyone financing beds, flights or venues has to price. This chapter measures that shape and compares the West African December with the summer and Eid calendars of other diasporas.

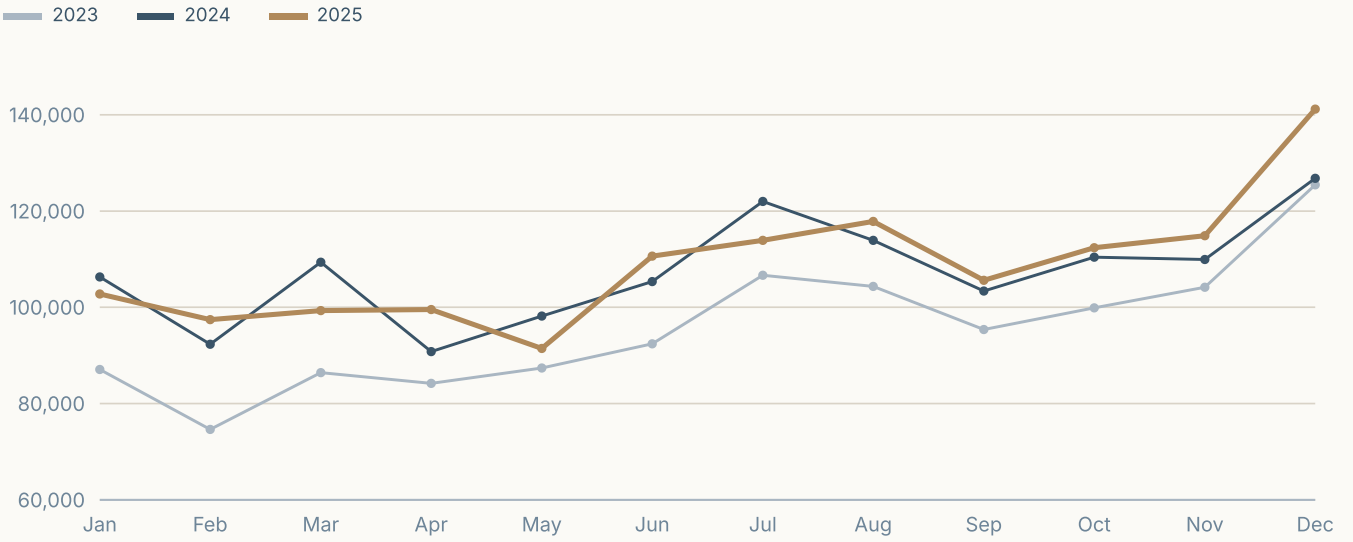
THE DECEMBER EFFECT

December added 14,395 arrivals in 2025. The other eleven months together added 3,763

EXHIBIT 4

December is Ghana's peak month every year, and in 2025 it pulled away

International arrivals to Ghana by month, 2023 to 2025



Source: Ghana Tourism Authority, Ghana Tourism Report 2025 (June 2026), Table 1 (Ghana Immigration Service data). Monthly figures reconcile to the annual totals.

December was Ghana's busiest month in each of the past three years: 125,461 arrivals in 2023, 126,791 in 2024 and 141,186 in 2025. Its share of the year is steady at 9.8% to 10.9%. What changed in 2025 was growth. December rose 11.4%; January to November rose 0.3%. December supplied 79% of the national increase of 18,158.

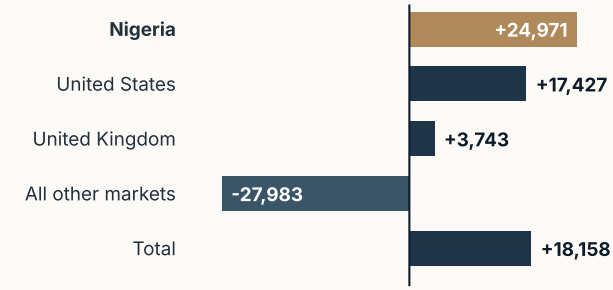
Measured as the excess over an ordinary month, the December effect is modest: 35,206 arrivals above the January to November average in 2025, 2.7% of the year, after 1.6% in 2024 and 2.8% in 2023.

The visitors are changing too. The United States remained the largest market with 155,289 arrivals, up 13%, but Nigeria grew 22% to 136,552 and added more visitors than the United States did. Ghana's December is becoming a regional West African product as well as a diaspora one, which widens the market for promoters and hotels alike.

EXHIBIT 5

Nigeria added more visitors to Ghana than the United States did

Change in international arrivals to Ghana by source market, 2025 vs 2024



Source: Ghana Tourism Authority, Ghana Tourism Report 2025, Table 2.
Heirstone analysis. All other markets = total change less the three named.

+11.4%
December arrivals, 2025 vs 2024

+0.3%
January to November arrivals, 2025 vs 2024

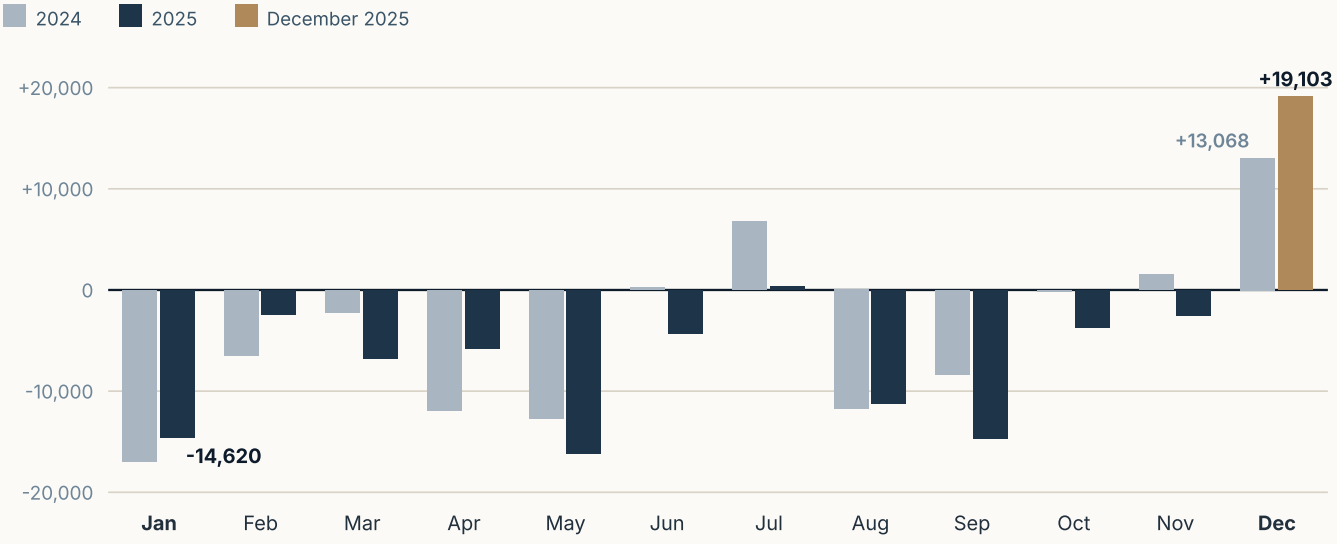
ARRIVALS AND DEPARTURES

Air data show a net inflow of 13,000 to 19,000 passengers in each of the past two Decembers, reversed in January

EXHIBIT 6

December is the month in which arrivals most exceed departures; January reverses it

International air passengers to and from Ghana, arrivals minus departures, by month, 2024 and 2025



Source: Ghana Civil Aviation Authority, General Statistics: International, 2024 and 2025. **Heirstone analysis.** Monthly arrivals less departures. The series includes Ghanaian residents travelling abroad.

The Ghana Civil Aviation Authority publishes international passenger arrivals and departures by month. In most months more people leave than arrive, because the series includes residents travelling abroad: across 2025 departures exceeded arrivals by 62,594. December is the exception. In December 2025 arrivals exceeded departures by 19,103, and in December 2024 by 13,068. In January 2025 the flow reversed, with 14,620 more departures than arrivals, as it had in January 2024.

That net December inflow is the most direct measure available of the temporary population the season adds: people who are not in the country at the end of November and have gone by the end of January, on top of visitors who come and go within December. Each of them needs a bed over the holidays, and Chapter 3 shows where most of them find it.

The same series can track policy. Ghana's festive visa-on-arrival window covers the weeks in which the flow turns positive, and its effect can be read off the GCAA tables each year.

+19,103

net air passenger inflow to Ghana in December 2025

-14,620

net outflow in January 2025, after the 2024 season

1.29x

December 2025 air arrivals against the monthly average

CALENDARS

December is a West African calendar. Other diasporas travel in summer or at Eid

EXHIBIT 7

December leads in Ghana, Cabo Verde and on the Kenyan coast; Senegal and Morocco peak in summer

Each month's traffic as a multiple of the series' monthly average (1.00 = average month)

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Ghana arrivals 2025, all entry points	0.94	0.89	0.91	0.91	0.84	1.02	1.05	1.08	0.97	1.03	1.05	**1.30**
Ghana air arrivals 2025, GCAA	0.92	0.80	0.90	0.94	0.91	0.99	1.10	1.10	0.97	1.04	1.04	**1.29**
Cabo Verde EU-27 air passengers, 2025	1.08	1.00	1.00	0.93	0.80	0.84	1.04	1.11	0.91	0.93	1.15	**1.22**
Nigeria EU-27 air passengers, 2025	1.09	0.80	0.82	1.01	0.95	1.00	1.06	1.08	1.08	1.01	1.00	**1.10**
Senegal EU-27 air passengers, 2025	1.14	1.01	0.97	0.97	0.81	0.90	**1.16**	1.12	0.89	0.92	0.99	1.11
Morocco EU-27 air passengers, 2025	0.89	0.90	0.87	1.07	1.02	0.97	1.04	**1.15**	1.00	1.09	0.98	1.03
Kenya arrivals 2024, all entry points	1.01	0.98	0.91	0.77	0.85	1.02	1.14	**1.25**	1.02	1.01	0.92	1.13
Mombasa arrivals 2024, Moi International	1.46	1.39	1.06	0.39	0.35	0.57	0.95	1.18	0.92	1.05	1.16	**1.52**

Source: Ghana Tourism Authority (2025); Ghana Civil Aviation Authority (2025); Eurostat avia_paexcc, passengers carried between EU-27 and partner country, both directions (updated 2026); Tourism Research Institute, Kenya (2024). **Heirstone analysis.** Month divided by annual total / 12. Bold = peak month.

Ghana's arrivals and Cabo Verde's air traffic with Europe peak in December. Kenya's national peak is August, driven by safari tourism, with December second; at Mombasa, the coastal gateway, December arrivals are 4.3 times the May trough. Nigeria's direct air traffic with the EU is small and flat, because its diaspora routes run through London, the United States and Gulf hubs.

Senegal's air traffic with Europe peaks in July and again in January. Morocco's barely moves, peaking 15% above average in August, because most of the Moroccan summer return travels by sea and road (Chapter 6). Where arrivals data are missing, fares fill the gap: the month in which a route is dearest shows when its diaspora travels.

Dec

dearest month for fares London-Lagos and Houston-Lagos; tied with July on London-Accra

Aug

dearest month Paris-Casablanca; June for Washington-Addis Ababa and Boston-Praia

May

dearest month Riyadh-Cairo, then March: the Eid holidays of Gulf-based Egyptians

A HEIRSTONE TYPOLOGY

Four homecoming markets, each with its own constraint and its own investable assets

The data in this chapter, the fare calendar and the accommodation surveys in Chapter 3 point to four distinct homecoming markets. They differ in timing and in who travels, and most of all in what limits them.

The December season is the most visible and the best measured. It is short and depends on air seats, and its visitors spend heavily but sleep mainly with family. The summer return is larger in volume but is a logistics operation: Morocco records more than four million diaspora arrivals in fourteen weeks, many of them through ports. The Eid return of Gulf-based Egyptians is frequent and short, and fares show its timing most clearly.

The heritage pilgrimage is the smallest by volume and the most sensitive. It runs all year at a low level, peaks around festivals, and brings long-staying visitors to small towns that have few of the beds they need. Its economics are covered in Chapter 5.

EXHIBIT 8

The Heirstone typology of homecoming markets

Four market types defined by calendar, traveller, accommodation and binding constraint

TYPE	WHERE	WHEN	WHO TRAVELS	WHERE THEY STAY	BINDING CONSTRAINT	ASSETS IT FAVOURS
The December season	Ghana, Nigeria, Cabo Verde, the Kenyan coast	Mid-December to early January	Nationals abroad, heritage visitors from the Americas, and a growing regional market (Nigeria +22% to Ghana)	Family homes (46% in Ghana), short lets (21%), upper-tier hotels	Air seats and fares; beds for two weeks or more	Managed apartments; upscale hotels with year-round business demand; multi-use venues
The summer return	Morocco, Senegal; Ethiopia and Cabo Verde from the US	June to September	Families of nationals abroad, many by car and ferry	Owned or family homes	Ports, roads and border processing: up to 80,000 arrivals a day in Morocco	Port and road services, coastal second homes, retail
The Eid return	Egyptians in the Gulf	Around the Eid holidays (May and March fare peaks)	Workers and families from Saudi Arabia and the UAE	Family homes and coastal holiday flats	Air seats and fares at Eid: Riyadh-Cairo peaks at 2.6 times the cheapest month	Family-sized coastal apartments; North Coast summer homes
The heritage pilgrimage	Cape Coast and Elmina, Gorée, Ouidah, Bunce Island, Badagry	All year, with festival peaks (PANAFEST July-August; Vodun Days January)	Heritage diaspora, often in groups, alongside domestic visitors	Capital-city beds and day trips; few beds in the towns	Beds, transport and interpretation in small towns	Guesthouses, small hotels, heritage-district regeneration

Source: Heirstone analysis. Derived from the arrivals, air passenger, fare and survey data in Chapters 2 to 5: Ghana Tourism Authority (2025); GCAA; Eurostat; KAYAK route pages (accessed 2026); Fondation Mohammed V (2026); Tourism Research Institute, Kenya.

> *West Africa's December is limited by air seats; Morocco's summer return by ports and roads.*

SEATS AND FARES

Ghana's December flights ran 11% above average while arrivals ran 29% above. Fares filled the gap

Ghana's air arrivals in December 2025 were 29% above the monthly average. International aircraft movements were 11% above. Fuller aircraft and higher fares made up the difference. OAG data for December 2025 show Cairo with 1.69 million departing seats, the most of any African airport in its list, Lagos with 496,000, 1.3% more than a year earlier, and Nairobi with 505,000 (+0.2%). Casablanca added 17.5% and Marrakech 13.6%.

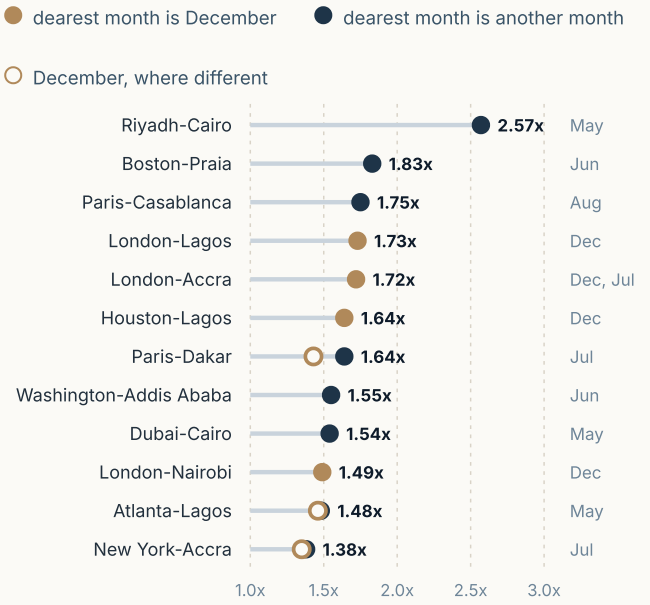
The fare premium is large. On KAYAK's route pages, which report median search prices by month over the past year, December is the dearest month from London to Lagos (GBP 1,115 return against GBP 646 in September) and from Houston to Lagos (US$1,918 against US$1,172 in February), and ties with July from London to Accra (GBP 1,078 against GBP 628). For a family of four flying London to Lagos, the December premium over the cheapest month is about GBP 1,900 before anyone books a bed. These are search prices, and fares actually paid may differ.

Demand absorbs the premium. On US Treasury reporting rates, a dollar bought about 29% fewer cedis in December 2025 than a year earlier, which made Ghana dearer for anyone earning dollars, yet December arrivals still rose 11.4%. This suggests December homecoming demand is not very sensitive to price, and that extra seats at the peak would be likely to fill.

EXHIBIT 9

December is the dearest month from London and Houston to Lagos and Accra; other corridors peak in summer or at Eid

Dearest month's median return fare as a multiple of the cheapest month's, 12 diaspora routes, trailing 12 months to 2026



Source: KAYAK route pages (kayak.com, .co.uk, .fr), accessed 2026: median round-trip search prices by departure month, top 0.1% removed. Search prices; fares paid may differ. **Heirstone analysis.** Ratio of dearest to cheapest month; right column = dearest month.

+1.3%
December departing seats at Lagos, 2025 vs 2024 (OAG)

+17.5%
December departing seats at Casablanca, 2025 vs 2024 (OAG)

GBP 1,876
December premium over the cheapest month for four return fares London-Lagos (Heirstone analysis)

-29%
cedis bought by one US dollar, December 2025 against December 2024; December arrivals still rose 11.4%

CHAPTER 3

03 Homes before hotels

Where homecoming visitors sleep decides who earns from them. Ghana's December survey gives the clearest answer in Africa.

46%

of December visitors to Ghana surveyed in 2025 stayed in a private home. 23% used a hotel.

The most useful number in GTA's December survey is the one least often quoted. Asked where they stayed, 46% of respondents named a private home, 23% a hotel, 21% an Airbnb, 11% an apartment and 6% a guesthouse; some gave more than one answer. A December visitor to Ghana was twice as likely to stay in a private home as in a hotel, and almost as likely to use an Airbnb as a hotel.

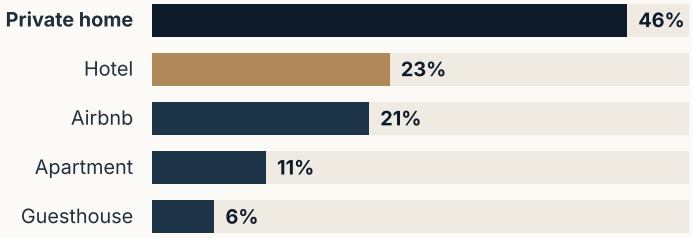
The profile is that of a repeat market. 29% of respondents were on a first visit, 22% on a second and 14% on a third, while 34% had been more than three times. Ninety-six per cent said they intend to return. Kenya shows a similar pattern outside its peaks: in an exit survey run in March and April 2023, 21.2% of visitors stayed with friends or relatives and 50.3% used hotels.

Lagos is the exception in the published numbers. The December 2024 figure claimed for the city gives hotels US$44m and short lets US$13m, 80% of the US$71.6m total between them, with short lets taking 23% of accommodation income. Without a method the split cannot be checked; if the claim is right, the platform data in Chapter 4 suggest that most Lagos short-let income never appears on a platform.

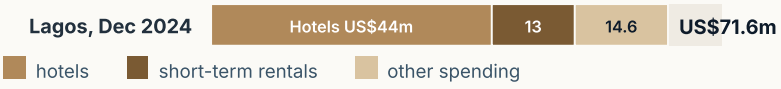
EXHIBIT 10

Fewer than one in four December visitors to Ghana used a hotel

Accommodation used, % of respondents (more than one answer allowed), December in GH survey, 2025



Lagos: December 2024 inflow by recipient, US$ million, as claimed



Source: Ghana Tourism Authority, Ghana Tourism Report 2025 (June 2026), p.36; ThisDay (15 February 2025), report cited in a Lagos State House of Assembly motion. **Heirstone analysis.** Lagos other = US$71.6m less hotels and short-term rentals.

29%

of December visitors to Ghana surveyed were on a first visit; 34% had been more than three times

96%

said they intend to return

80%

of the claimed Lagos December figure went to hotels and short lets

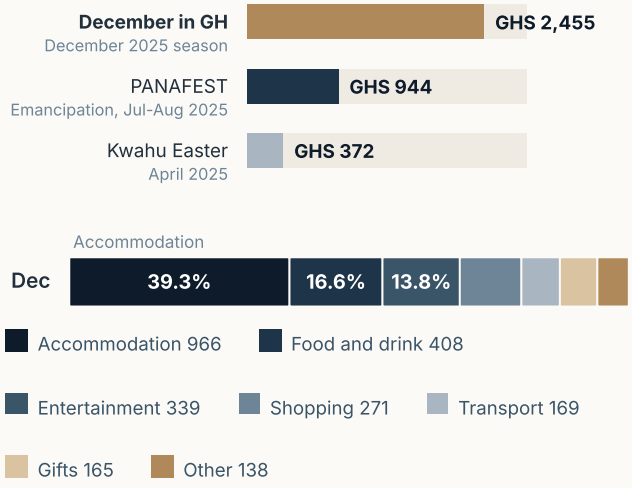
WHAT THEY SPEND

A December visitor spends 2.6 times as much a day as a heritage-festival visitor, and 39% of it on a bed

EXHIBIT 11

Daily spend in December is more than double that of the heritage season

Average daily expenditure per visitor, GHS, Ghana festival surveys 2025; and how the December figure divides, GHS a day



Source: Ghana Tourism Authority, Ghana Tourism Report 2025 (June 2026), pp.25-37. US$ equivalent of the December figure: about US$236 at GHS 10.4 = US$1 (US Treasury, 31 December 2025). The other surveys fall in months with different exchange rates, so they are compared in cedis.

December visitors spend more per day than any other group GTA surveyed: GHS 2,455 on average. That is 2.6 times the GHS 944 spent by a PANAFEST and Emancipation Day visitor and 6.6 times the GHS 372 at Kwahu's Easter paragliding festival. Accommodation is the largest line at GHS 966 a day, 39% of the total, followed by food and drink (GHS 408) and entertainment (GHS 339).

The heritage visitor is a different customer. PANAFEST's international visitors stayed about 15 nights, against a national average of 13, at less than half the December daily spend, and 65% of PANAFEST participants were Ghanaian residents. A long-staying, lower-spending guest suits guesthouses and serviced apartments better than resort hotels.

Kwahu's Easter visitors are different again: three-night stays, 66% first-timers and hotels around the festival at 91% occupancy.

In the December survey accommodation is the largest single item of visitor spending, so the kind of bed a visitor chooses largely decides who earns from the visit.

GHS 966
a day on accommodation by the average December visitor, about US$93

15 nights
average stay of international PANAFEST visitors, against 13 for all visitors to Ghana

65%
of PANAFEST and Emancipation participants were domestic

6.6x
December daily spend against a Kwahu Easter visitor (GHS 372)

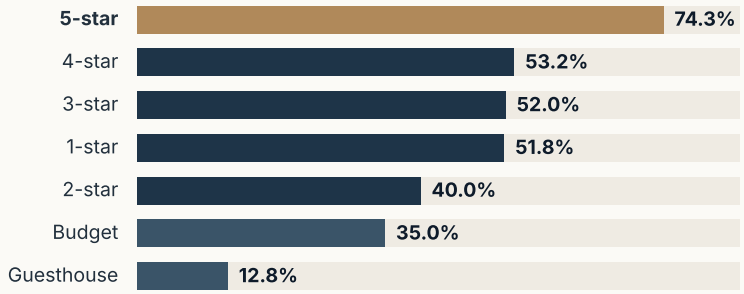
HOTELS

Ghana's five-star hotels ran at 74% occupancy in 2025; guesthouses at 13%

EXHIBIT 12

The top of the market fills; budget hotels and guesthouses do not

Average annual occupancy of licensed hotels in Ghana by grade, %, 2025



Source: Ghana Tourism Authority, Ghana Tourism Report 2025 (June 2026), Table 22. Annual averages; GTA does not publish monthly occupancy or room rates.

The hotel data confirm the split. Ghana's licensed five-star hotels ran 74.3% occupancy in 2025, four-star 53.2% and budget hotels 35.0%. Guesthouses fell to 12.8% from 32.0% in 2024. GTA publishes annual figures only, so December cannot be isolated, but the hotels that fill are those with year-round business and conference demand (31% and 7% of Ghana's arrivals) as well as December guests.

A festival on its own does not fill rooms. Around PANAFEST and Emancipation Day hotels averaged 23.5% occupancy and 52% of them were below 10%. Around Kwahu's mainly domestic Easter festival occupancy averaged 91%.

Supply is growing regardless. Licensed accommodation establishments rose 17.6% between 2023 and 2025, to 5,424, of which 932 are in Greater Accra and 345 in the Central Region. Informal supply is already large: AirROI tracks 2,997 active short lets in Accra, more than the 2,568 rooms in Ghana's entire branded hotel pipeline in W Hospitality Group's 2024 survey. Nearly half (47.6%) are one-bedroom units. At Christmas a new Accra hotel competes with family homes and with apartments let by their owners.

23.5%

average hotel occupancy around PANAFEST and Emancipation Day, 2025; 52% of hotels were below 10%

91%

average hotel occupancy around the Kwahu Easter festival

2,997

active Airbnb listings in Accra, against 2,568 rooms in Ghana's branded hotel pipeline (2024)

21.2%

of visitors to Kenya stayed with friends or relatives (exit survey, March-April 2023)



04

Twelve months to pay for one

The short let is the homecoming economy's signature asset. It suits family groups who want kitchens and space, a diaspora buyer can own it from abroad, and in December it fills.

Platform data allow that case to be tested. We used AirROI's public market data for the twelve months to July 2026 in nine cities, checked Accra against a second vendor, Airbtics, and set the results against long-let rents and prices from Global Property Guide and the Centre for Affordable Housing Finance in Africa.

The results are less favourable than the December story suggests. December brings in about one-eighth of a short-let year, and even at the peak most listings are empty more nights than they are let. On realised revenue the long let earns more than the short let wherever a fair comparison can be made.

45%

peak December occupancy of the average short let in Accra and Lagos

-8.8% to -24.1%

change in short-let revenue over the year to July 2026 across the large markets in the set; none rose

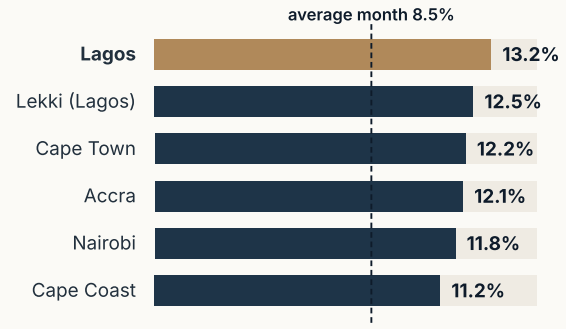
THE DECEMBER WEIGHT

December is worth 1.3 to 1.6 ordinary months of short-let revenue, and the lift comes from occupancy

EXHIBIT 13

December brings in about one-eighth of a short-let year

December revenue per listing as % of full-year revenue potential, Aug 2025 to Jul 2026



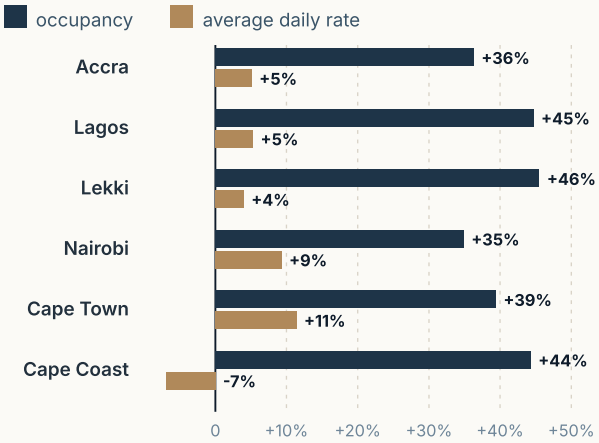
Source: AirROI market pages for each city, accessed 2026. **Heirstone analysis.** December revenue / (annual occupancy x average daily rate x 365). An average month is 31/365 = 8.5%.

December is the peak short-let month in Accra, Lagos, Lekki, Nairobi, Cape Town and Cape Coast. Measured against each market's full-year revenue potential, it is worth between 11.2% (Cape Coast) and 13.2% (Lagos), against 8.5% for an average month. Lagos is the most December-dependent market in the set. Dakar and Cairo peak in August, with December among their three busiest months; Marrakesh peaks in April, and December falls outside its peak season.

EXHIBIT 14

In December occupancy rises by more than a third; nightly rates in West Africa barely move

December occupancy and average daily rate against the twelve-month average, % difference



Source: AirROI market pages, Aug 2025 to Jul 2026, accessed 2026. **Heirstone analysis.** December value / annual value - 1.

In Accra occupancy rises from 32.8% over the year to 44.7% in December while the average nightly rate moves from US$99 to US$104. In Lagos occupancy rises from 31.3% to 45.3% and the rate from US$95 to US$100. Nairametrics reported quotes of NGN180,000 to NGN300,000 a night (about US$121 to US$201) for December 2025 in Lekki, Victoria Island and Ikoyi, against NGN120,000 to NGN200,000 at other times, with 14-night minimum stays. Spikes of that kind are more likely in hotels and off-platform lets, which AirROI does not see.

13.2%
of a year's short-let revenue potential falls in December in Lagos, the highest in the set

+4-5%
December nightly rate against the annual average in Accra, Lagos and Lekki

+36-46%
December occupancy against the annual average in the same markets

Aug, Apr
peak months for short lets in Dakar and Cairo (August) and Marrakesh (April)

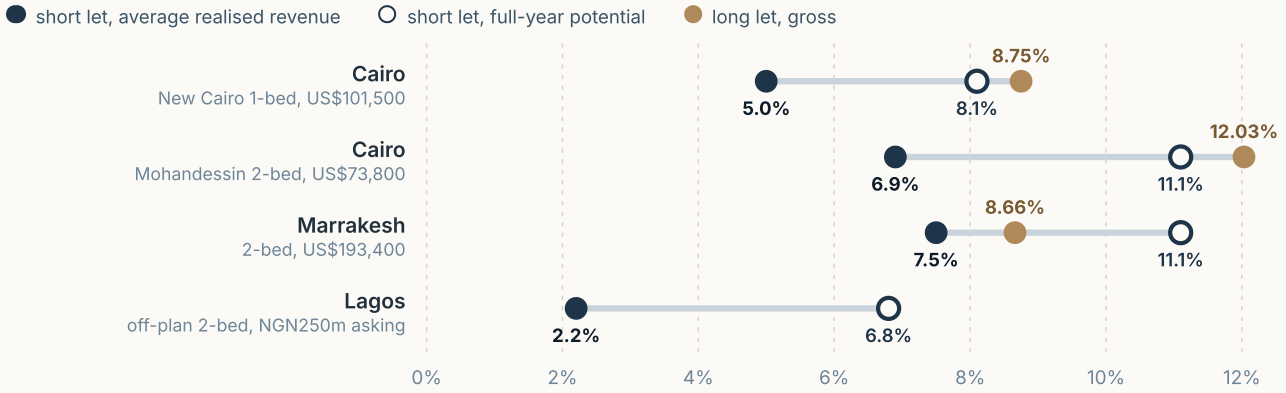
YIELDS

On realised revenue, short lets yield less than long lets on the same unit

EXHIBIT 15

Realised short-let revenue falls short of a long let in every city where the two can be compared

Gross yield, % of unit price: realised short-let revenue, full-year short-let potential and long-let rent, 2025-26



Source: AirROI (Cairo, Marrakesh, Lekki), accessed 2026; Global Property Guide, Egypt Q2 2026 and Morocco Q3 2026; The Guardian (Nigeria), 22 December 2025; NGN1,450 = US$1 (US Treasury, 31 December 2025). **Heirstone analysis.** Average realised revenue and potential (occupancy x ADR x 365) divided by unit price. Gross of all costs; short-let averages are not unit-matched.

AirROI's average realised revenue per Cairo listing is US$5,093 a year: 5.0% of the US$101,500 Global Property Guide gives for a New Cairo one-bedroom flat, and 6.9% of a US$73,800 two-bedroom in Mohandessin. Let long, the same units yield 8.75% and 12.03% gross, the highest long-let yields in the comparison. In Marrakesh realised short-let revenue of US$14,527 is 7.5% of a US$193,400 two-bedroom that yields 8.66% on a long let. A prime Lagos two-bedroom marketed off-plan from NGN250m (about US$172,000, an asking price reported by The Guardian, Nigeria) would earn 2.2% on Lekki's average realised revenue, and 6.8% only if it matched the market's full-year potential.

In Dakar the average short let earns US$343 a month, against US$458 for an average F3 apartment let long. In Accra it earns US$529 a month on AirROI's average and about US$1,080 on Airbtics' median, against US$1,000 to US$1,800 for a prime two-bedroom let long. All these figures are gross. Platform fees, cleaning, furnishing and management weigh more heavily on short lets. For many diaspora owners the arrangement that survives the numbers is a furnished long let with the owner's own December stay written into it.

Two cautions apply to all platform data. Vendors disagree: depending on the source, Accra's occupancy is 33% to 45% and its nightly rate US$80 to US$99 (AirROI average, Airbtics median). And much of the market is invisible. By our estimate, Airbnb-visible December 2025 revenue in Lagos is about US$2.07m, 16% of the US$13m short-let figure claimed for December 2024 in the report the Lagos Assembly cited.

16%

Airbnb-visible share of the December short-let income claimed for Lagos (Heirstone analysis)

1.2%

of Accra listings professionally managed; Lagos 0.4%, Cape Town 11.4%

0.6%

of Accra listings, about 18, show registration, four years after Ghana's licensing deadline

A HEIRSTONE FRAMEWORK

The twelve-month test: five questions for any project justified by homecoming demand

Homecoming demand is dependable and recurring, and it is growing in West Africa. The evidence in Chapters 2 to 4 shows it is also concentrated in a few weeks, housed largely by families and constrained by seats. December alone cannot carry an investment. We therefore propose a discipline for any hotel, apartment scheme, venue or resort whose case rests on diaspora or heritage visitors: five tests, each tied to a measured fact, which together ask whether the asset can pay its way across twelve months.

Exhibit 16 applies the tests to seven asset types using the evidence in this report. The pattern is consistent. Assets with a second, year-round market (business travellers in capital-city hotels, long stays in serviced apartments) pass. Assets built only for the season fail the tests even when they are full in December.

1 **The December test**
Does the project meet its return target if December brings only its measured weight, 11 to 13% of a year's revenue, at roughly the annual average rate?

2 **The home-stay test**
Is demand sized on paid bed-nights, after family stays? In Ghana 46% of December visitors stayed in private homes and 23% in hotels.

3 **The other-eleven-months test**
Which named segment fills January to November: business (31% of Ghana's arrivals), conferences (7%), domestic festivals, long stays?

4 **The seats test**
Does the plan assume more peak visitors than airlines carry? Ghana's December flights rose 11% above average; Lagos seats rose 1.3%.

5 **The licence test**
Can the asset be registered and taxed as it stands? About 0.6% of Accra short lets show registration under rules in force since 2022.

EXHIBIT 16

The Heirstone twelve-month test applied to seven homecoming assets

Assessment of each asset type against the five tests

TEST	UPSCALE HOTEL, CAPITAL CITY	MID-SCALE OR BUDGET HOTEL	SERVICED APARTMENTS, MANAGED	SINGLE SHORT LET, OWNER ABROAD	EVENTS VENUE	HERITAGE-TOWN GUESTHOUSE	RESORT IN A NEW COASTAL DESTINATION
1 December	●	○	●	◑	○	◑	○
2 Home-stay	●	○	●	◑	●	◑	◑
3 Other eleven months	●	◑	●	○	◑	◑	○
4 Seats	●	◑	●	◑	○	◑	○
5 Licence	●	●	●	○	●	●	●
Heirstone verdict	Build where business demand exists	Weak as a homecoming play	Strongest fit with the evidence	Prefer a furnished long let with December self-use	Only as an all-year, multi-use venue	Small, phased, tied to heritage programmes	Needs a year-round market before the keys

● passes on the evidence ◑ depends on location and operator ○ fails on the evidence

Source: Heirstone analysis. Assessment based on the evidence in Chapters 2 to 5, including Ghana Tourism Authority (2025), GCAA, OAG, AirROI and Benin's Bénin Révélé project sheets. Intended as a screen ahead of full project feasibility.



CHAPTER 5

05 Heritage towns and the coast

The places most closely tied to the Atlantic slave trade are small towns on the coast between Senegal and Nigeria: Gorée off Dakar, Bunce Island near Freetown, Cape Coast and Elmina in Ghana, Ouidah in Benin and Badagry west of Lagos. Elmina Castle, built in 1482, is one of the oldest European buildings outside Europe, according to UNESCO. Gorée was among the first twelve sites inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List in 1978; Cape Coast and Elmina followed in 1979.

These sites carry a meaning that no visitor statistic captures, and they call for care in how they are developed and described. They are also the places where accommodation for homecoming visitors is thinnest.

Cape Coast Castle recorded 141,523 visits in 2025 and Elmina Castle 100,135. Together that is fewer than the 302,523 visits to the Kwame Nkrumah Memorial Park in Accra. Across Ghana's 55 monitored sites, non-residents made 16% of visits.

The towns around the castles have little of the accommodation homecoming visitors use. AirROI tracks 68 active short lets in Cape Coast, 47% of them private rooms, at 18.5% occupancy over the year, although revenue grew 35.7%, the only market in the set to grow. Elmina and Ada do not appear among the 21 Ghanaian markets it tracks.

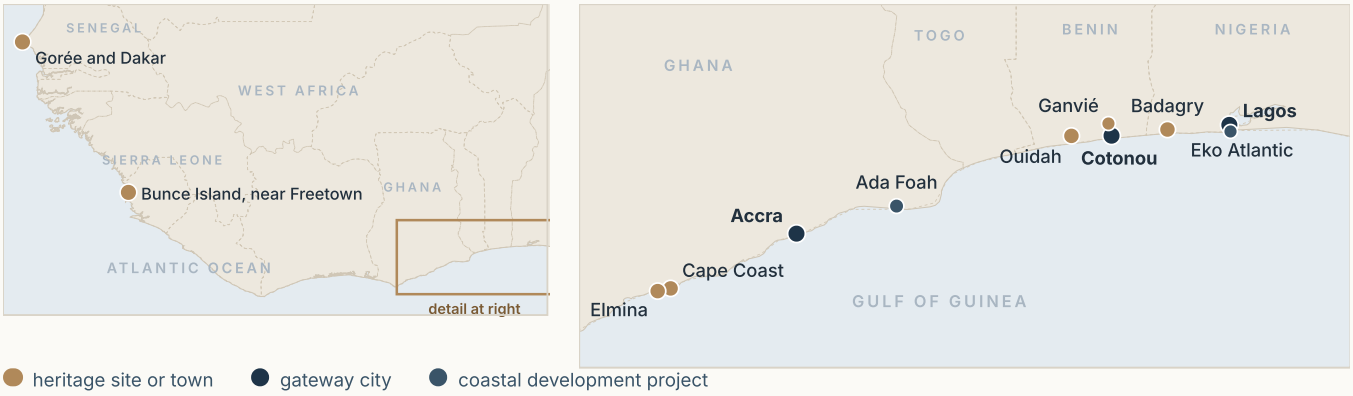
THE HERITAGE COAST

Every heritage town in this report lies within about 140 km of a gateway city

EXHIBIT 17

The heritage sites sit in small coastal towns a short drive from the capitals and their hotel stock

Heritage sites and towns, gateway cities and coastal projects named in this report; right panel shows the Ghana to Lagos coast

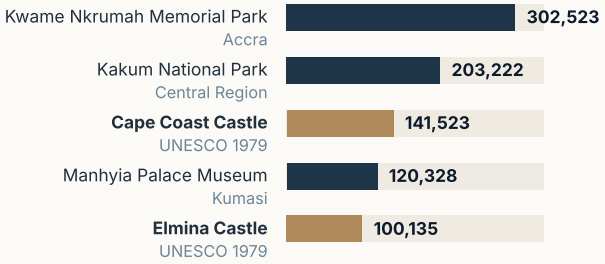


Source: Natural Earth (land, borders); GeoNames gazetteer (castles at Cape Coast and Elmina; town or city points elsewhere); Eko Atlantic is an approximate position beside Victoria Island. **Heirstone analysis.** Straight-line distances from coordinates: Accra to Cape Coast 126 km, to Elmina 138 km; Cotonou to Ouidah 37 km; Lagos to Badagry 57 km; Dakar to Gorée 6 km; Freetown to Bunce Island 23 km.

EXHIBIT 18

Ghana's two castles together draw fewer visits than one Accra memorial park

Recorded visits to selected heritage and visitor sites in Ghana, 2025



Source: Ghana Tourism Authority, Ghana Tourism Report 2025, Table 6 (residents and non-residents).

The geography explains the bed problem. Every heritage town on the map lies within about 140 km of a capital or gateway city, close enough for a day trip by road. Cotonou is 37 km from Ouidah and Lagos 57 km from Badagry. Visitors can see the sites without staying the night, and the thin supply of beds in the towns suggests that many do just that.

The Central Region had 345 licensed accommodation establishments in 2025 against 932 in Greater Accra. Heritage visitors who do stay are the long-stay, lower-spend guests of Chapter 3. That points to guesthouses, small hotels and serviced rooms built in step with the heritage programme.

241,658
visits to Cape Coast and Elmina castles combined in 2025

16%
of visits to Ghana's 55 monitored sites were by non-residents

68
active short lets in Cape Coast; Elmina and Ada are not tracked

345
licensed accommodation establishments in the Central Region, against 932 in Greater Accra

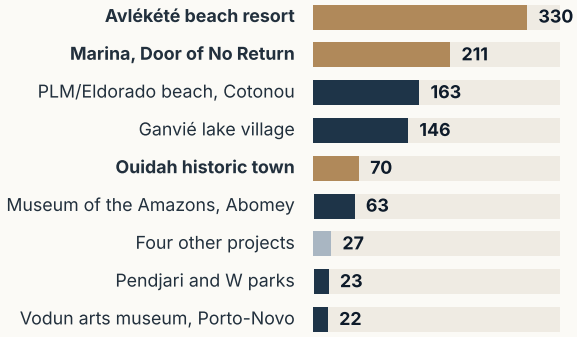
BENIN AND THE WIDER COAST

Benin has costed US$1.06bn of tourism projects, and more than half of it is on the Ouidah coast

EXHIBIT 19

Two Ouidah coast projects take 51% of Benin's tourism budget

Benin government tourism projects (PAG 2021-2026) by estimated budget, US$ million at XOF553.75 = US$1 (31 December 2025)



Source: Government of Benin, Bénin Révélé tourism projects page and project sheets 139, 141, 143 and 147, accessed 2026; US Treasury reporting rate. **Heirstone analysis.** FCFA budgets converted; four other projects = FCFA585bn total less the eight listed. Gold = Ouidah.

On the published budget the Avlékété resort costs about FCFA1.08bn, roughly US$1.94m, per key (Heirstone analysis), a figure that includes seafront public works. Recovering a cost of that order would need year-round trade well beyond the January festival.

Benin is the only government in the set that we found with a published, costed capital programme for heritage tourism. Its Bénin Révélé platform lists twelve tourism projects whose budgets sum to FCFA585bn by our count, about US$1.06bn. Two Ouidah coast projects take 51%: a beach resort at Avlékété (FCFA183bn), with Club Med named on the project sheet as maître d'oeuvre (project designer), a 150-room hotel and about 20 lodge units in the mangrove; and a marina tourism complex beside the Door of No Return at Djègbadji (FCFA117bn), with a lagoon development, hotels and memorial promenades. A further FCFA39bn is rebuilding Ouidah's historic town, its forts, a memorial pathway and an artisan village.

The platform lists the marina and the historic-town project as ongoing past their programmed end dates, 2024 and 2023 respectively. They sit alongside Vodun Days, held in Ouidah each January since 2024, and the Afro-descendant nationality law in force since July 2025.

Elsewhere on the coast investment is private and smaller. Near Ada Foah on Ghana's Volta estuary, Trasacco Estates has planned a Hilton resort and spa, according to the Ghana News Agency. In Lagos, Eko Atlantic markets freehold plots in a free zone that allows full foreign ownership, and names no hotel operator on its website. Gorée is an island of 28 hectares, 3.5 km off Dakar, according to UNESCO. On Bunce Island, the Bunce Island Coalition has launched a US$5m project to conserve what remains, CNN reported in 2013.

US$1.94m
budget per key at the Avlékété resort, including seafront public works (Heirstone analysis)

51%
of Benin's FCFA585bn tourism budget is on two Ouidah coast projects

2024
programmed completion of the Door of No Return marina, still listed as ongoing

150 + 20
hotel rooms and mangrove lodge units planned at Avlékété

CHAPTER 6

06 North Africa and Sub-Saharan Africa

The Heirstone Homecoming Benchmark sets out, for ten markets, what is known about the size, timing and policy of homecoming travel. Measurement is the main gap: seven of the ten markets score zero or one, and only Morocco counts its diaspora directly. Policy, meanwhile, is moving from events to status and housing: Ghana offers a Right of Abode to persons of African descent, Egypt has offered Bait El Watan land to nationals abroad since 2012, and Benin opened a nationality route in 2025.

EXHIBIT 20

The Heirstone Homecoming Benchmark: only Ghana and Kenya have four of the five measures that matter

Ten homecoming markets: calendar type, diaspora visibility, seasonal peak, fare premium, short-let seasonality, policy instruments and evidence score

MARKET	CALENDAR TYPE	DIASPORA IN ARRIVALS	PEAK MONTH (RATIO TO AVERAGE)	DEAREST-MONTH FARE PREMIUM	DECEMBER SHORT-LET WEIGHT	RESIDENCE, NATIONALITY AND RECEPTION	EVIDENCE (0-5)
NORTH AFRICA							
Morocco	Summer return	Counted: MRE 49% of arrivals (2024)	Aug, 1.15 (EU air); Marhaba peak days 1.9x season average	1.75 Paris-Casablanca (Aug)	Marrakesh peaks in April	Operation Marhaba since 2001: 26 reception spaces, about 1,400 staff	3
Egypt	Eid return	Outside the 19m; 9.4m nationals abroad (2017 census)	Not found	2.57 Riyadh-Cairo (May); 1.54 Dubai-Cairo (May)	Cairo peaks in August	Bait El Watan land for nationals abroad (since 2012); dollar housing offers (2025)	1
WEST AFRICA: ANGLOPHONE							
Ghana	December season; heritage	Not counted; VFR proxy 23%	Dec, 1.30 (arrivals)	1.72 London-Accra (Dec, Jul); 1.38 New York-Accra (Jul)	Accra 12.1%; Cape Coast 11.2%	Right of Abode; festive visa-on-arrival window; Beyond the Return 2020-30	4
Nigeria	December season	No official series	Dec, 1.10 (EU air only)	1.73 London-Lagos (Dec); 1.64 Houston-Lagos (Dec)	Lagos 13.2%; Lekki 12.5%	Lagos Assembly motion to expand December season (2025)	1
Sierra Leone	Heritage pilgrimage	No series found	Not found	Not sampled	Not tracked	None identified	0
WEST AFRICA: FRANCOPHONE AND LUSOPHONE							
Senegal	Summer return; heritage	No series since 2017	Jul, 1.16 (EU air); second peak Jan	1.64 Paris-Dakar (Jul)	Dakar peaks in August	20,000 diaspora homes reserved (2021); Sessen diaspora city, 200 ha	1
Benin	Heritage pilgrimage; January festival	No series found	Not found	Not sampled	Not tracked	Afro-descendant nationality (in force July 2025); FCFA585bn tourism programme	0
Cabo Verde	December season; summer return	No series found	Dec, 1.22 (EU air)	1.83 Boston-Praia (Jun)	Not tracked	None identified	0
EAST AFRICA							
Kenya	August safari; December coast	Not counted; VFR proxy 22%	Aug, 1.25; Mombasa Dec, 1.52	1.49 London-Nairobi (Dec)	Nairobi 11.8%	None identified	4
Ethiopia	Summer return	No series after 2019	Not found	1.55 Washington-Addis Ababa (Jun)	Not tracked	None identified	0

Source: Moroccan Ministry of Tourism; Fondation Mohammed V; Ghana Tourism Authority; GCAA; Tourism Research Institute, Kenya; Eurostat; KAYAK; AirROI; Ghana Immigration Service; myafroorigins.bj; Dakaractu; AllAfrica (Le Soleil); ThisDay; Egyptian Ministry of Housing; CAPMAS; World Bank WDI; CNN. **Heirstone analysis.** Peak ratio = peak month / monthly average. Fare premium = dearest / cheapest month. Evidence score counts five measures found in the public sources reviewed: monthly arrivals; diaspora counted separately; visitor spend survey; accommodation-use survey; independent short-let data. The score measures published data, not market size. Not found does not mean none exists.

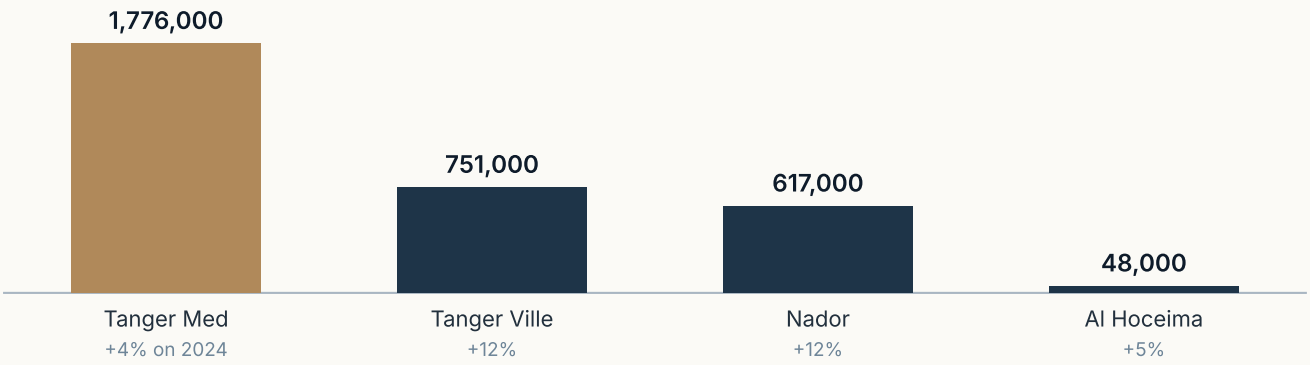
NORTH AFRICA

Morocco records more than four million diaspora arrivals in fourteen summer weeks. Egypt's homecoming peaks at Eid

EXHIBIT 21

Tanger Med carried more than half of Operation Marhaba's sea passengers in 2025

Operation Marhaba passengers through Moroccan ports, summer 2025, and change on summer 2024



Source: Hespress FR (2025), citing port authority and ministry figures. **Heirstone analysis.** Tanger Med share = 1.776 million of 3.2 million Marhaba port passengers, 55%.

Morocco: a port and road operation

Morocco counts its nationals abroad at every border post. In 2024 they were 49% of 17.4 million arrivals, and total arrivals reached nearly 20 million in 2025, according to the ministry.

The return is concentrated in one operation. Operation Marhaba, run by the Fondation Mohammed V pour la Solidarité since 2001, recorded more than 4.1 million MRE arrivals between 10 June and 15 September 2026, about 41,800 a day, with peak days of up to 80,000. Set against roughly 8.5 million MRE arrivals in 2024, the window carries close to half of annual diaspora entries (an indicative calculation across different years). Much of it travels by sea: in summer 2025 Moroccan ports handled 3.2 million Marhaba passengers and 739,000 vehicles, 1.776 million of the passengers through Tanger Med.

Air traffic between the EU and Morocco peaks only 15% above its monthly average, and Marrakesh short lets peak in April, so platforms see little of the summer return. The family and second homes that house it are covered in our companion report.

Egypt: the Eid return

Egypt's homecoming shows most clearly in fares and seats. CAPMAS counted 9.4 million Egyptians living abroad at the 2017 census. Fares show when they travel: Riyadh-Cairo is dearest in May and March, 2.6 times the cheapest month, and Dubai-Cairo in May. Cairo had 1.69 million departing seats in December 2025, the most among the African airports in OAG's published list.

Egypt's short lets are concentrated in Cairo (3,199 listings), Hurghada (1,345), Gamsha on the Red Sea (1,033) and Giza (767). The North Coast shows only 38 tracked listings but the highest nightly rate in Egypt, US$227, which suggests a market of family-owned summer homes that rarely reach the platforms. The state serves this market directly: Bait El Watan has sold plots in the new cities to Egyptians abroad for dollars since 2012, and in October 2025 Your Home in Egypt offered nationals abroad 785 homes, including at New Alamein and Marina Alamein on the North Coast.

We found no published series for Algeria, Tunisia or Libya that separates nationals living abroad, so they are not benchmarked.

SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA

West Africa has the season and the heritage sites. Only Ghana measures them

ANGLOPHONE WEST AFRICA

Ghana

Ghana has the evidence base the rest of the region lacks and several diaspora instruments: a Right of Abode for persons of African descent, which asks applicants to show an economic contribution and six years of tax clearance; citizenship conferred at state ceremonies, including on a prominent US musician in 2024; the festive visa window; and Beyond the Return, a programme running to 2030. December hotel data, the survey's sample size and Right of Abode grant numbers are not published.

Nigeria

Nigeria has West Africa's largest December market by reputation and no official count of it. The Lagos figure has no method, we found no national arrivals series, and EU air data capture only 600,668 passengers a year because the main diaspora routes run to London, the United States and Gulf hubs. Calabar Carnival, founded by the Cross River State government in 2004, runs through December; the state tourism bureau said the 2025 edition drew more than 248,000 visitors, without publishing a method. The Guardian (Nigeria) reports a 675-hectare Diaspora City in the capital territory with more than 17,000 planned homes.

Sierra Leone

Bunce Island, in the Sierra Leone River near Freetown, is the only one of some 40 large slave-trade castles on the West African coast to have sent appreciable numbers of captives to what is now the United States, according to the coalition conserving it. CNN reported in 2013 that it drew only a few visitors a year, mostly foreigners and expatriates. We found no arrivals series.

FRANCOPHONE WEST AFRICA

Senegal

Senegal has two diaspora seasons. Air traffic with the EU peaked in July 2025 and again in January, Paris-Dakar fares are dearest in July, and Dakar's short lets earn most in August. Its heritage anchors are Gorée and Dak'Art, the Dakar biennale, whose 2024 edition showed 58 artists from Africa and the diaspora. Its instruments are housing programmes: a 2021 framework reserving 20,000 units of the national 100,000-home programme for Senegalese abroad, and a 200-hectare diaspora city at Sessen, between Mbour and Thiadiaye, with up to 6,000 homes. The latest international arrivals figure in the World Bank series is 1.38 million, for 2017.

Benin

Benin has a nationality route for Afro-descendants but no visitor data we could find. Its law offers a genealogical route with a three-month processing target; no application numbers are published. Vodun Days give the coast a January peak that complements December elsewhere.

Côte d'Ivoire, Cameroon and DR Congo

We found no homecoming-specific public data for these francophone markets, so they are not benchmarked. Demand there may still be large.

LUSOPHONE AND EAST AFRICA

Cabo Verde, Kenya and Ethiopia

Cabo Verde's EU air traffic peaks in December (169,655 passengers in 2025), with Boston-Praia fares dearest in June. Kenya shows how a diaspora peak can hide inside a national one: VFR was 22% of 2024 arrivals (526,071 visitors), and land-border arrivals peaked in August and December. Ethiopia's fare peak is June; its arrivals data stop in 2019 (812,000).

600,668
EU-27 air passengers to and from Nigeria in 2025; the main diaspora routes run elsewhere

3 months
Benin's target for processing an Afro-descendant nationality file

20,000
homes reserved for Senegalese abroad in the national programme (2021)

11.4%
of Cape Town short lets are professionally managed: the region's benchmark

CHAPTER 7

07 What each reader should do

Each recommendation is tied to evidence in the report and grouped by the reader best placed to act on it.

GOVERNMENTS AND TOURISM AUTHORITIES

1 Count nationals living abroad at the border

Add a residence question to arrival cards and publish arrivals of nationals living abroad each month, as Morocco does. Egypt's 9.4 million nationals abroad, and Ghana's 23% VFR share, show how large this market can be.

2 Publish December quickly, with the method

Release December arrivals within weeks and survey results with sample size and respondents' country of residence. Ghana's December 2025 data appeared in June 2026, six months after the season.

3 Label projections as projections

Publish targets, results and methods separately. Ghana's 2019 projections are easily mistaken for results, and the US$71.6m claimed for Lagos has no published method.

4 Make registration easy before enforcing it

About 0.6% of Accra short lets show registration four years after Ghana's 2022 deadline. A simple online route and a low levy would bring the stock into the tax base over time.

5 Put beds and transport into heritage programmes

Cape Coast has 68 tracked short lets and PANAFEST hotels averaged 23.5% occupancy. Plan accommodation, transport and interpretation together with the monuments.

AIRLINES, AIRPORTS, PORTS AND PROMOTERS

6 Add capacity in the direction of travel

Ghana's net air flow was +19,103 in December 2025 and -14,620 in January 2025. Extra sections should run inbound in December and outbound in January, sold early to repeat visitors; 96% intend to return.

7 Plan ports and roads for peak days

Morocco's Marhaba peaks at 80,000 arrivals a day and 1.9 times its season average. Summer-return markets need port, border and road capacity sized to the peak day.

8 Sell the region as well as the diaspora

Nigeria added more visitors to Ghana in 2025 than the United States. Promoters should price and route for West African visitors, and spread events into January, Easter and July.

DEVELOPERS

9 Build for twelve months

Managed one- and two-bedroom apartments that take families in December and 30-night stays the rest of the year fit the evidence best. Cape Town shows the model: 11.4% of listings professionally managed and 40.1% with 30-night minimums.

10 In heritage towns, build small and in step

Guesthouses and small hotels phased with heritage programmes suit long-staying, lower-spend visitors. Large resorts need a year-round market first.

HOTEL AND SHORT-LET INVESTORS, LENDERS AND OPERATORS

11 Underwrite December at its measured weight

Model December at 11 to 13% of annual revenue and at close to the annual nightly rate (+4 to 5% in Accra and Lagos). Treat anything above that as upside.

12 Size demand on paid beds

With 46% of December visitors in private homes, arrivals overstate paid demand. Start from hotel, apartment and short-let shares of visitors.

13 Triangulate data and adjust for what is unseen

Vendors put Accra's occupancy anywhere from 33% to 45%, and platform data show about 16% of the short-let income claimed for Lagos. Use two vendors and a local survey.

14 Stress-test currency both ways

A dollar bought about 29% fewer cedis at the end of 2025 than a year earlier, and Ghana's receipts per visitor fell 11.3% in 2025. Test revenue and debt service in both directions.

15 Back professional operators

Only 1.2% of Accra and 0.4% of Lagos listings are professionally managed. A licensed, well-run operating platform is the gap in the market.

HERITAGE-SITE MANAGERS AND PROMOTERS

16 Turn day visits into stays

Cape Coast and Elmina castles drew 241,658 visits in 2025, yet Cape Coast has 68 tracked short lets. Evening programmes, guided multi-day routes and partnerships with local guesthouses give visitors a reason to stay the night.

17 Use the whole calendar

PANAFEST in July and August, Vodun Days in January and the Kwahu Easter festival already exist. Marketing them to December's repeat visitors, 96% of whom intend to return, spreads demand into months that hotels need.

WHAT WE WILL WATCH IN THE NEXT TWELVE MONTHS

Ghana, December 2026
Arrivals against 141,186, and whether the GCAA net inflow again exceeds 19,000.

Benin
The first published count of nationality applications and grants under the 2024 law.

Lagos
A December figure with a published method and visitor count.

Morocco
Marhaba 2027 against 4.1 million, and any port capacity added for peak days.

Egypt
Fares and seats on Gulf routes over the 2027 Eid holidays, and further handovers of Bait El Watan plots to Egyptians abroad.

> *In Ghana, 46% of December visitors stayed in a private home. Paid beds have to earn their keep in the other eleven months.*

NOTES, SOURCES AND DEFINITIONS

Definitions. *Homecoming travel*: trips to Africa by members of the diaspora, whether nationals living abroad or descendants of Africans taken in the Atlantic slave trade. *MRE*: Marocains résidant à l'étranger, counted separately at Moroccan border posts. *VFR*: visiting friends and relatives, a trip-purpose category used as a proxy where the diaspora is not counted. *Peak-to-average ratio*: the peak month divided by the annual total / 12. *Fare premium*: median return search fare in the dearest month divided by the cheapest month. *December weight*: December short-let revenue divided by full-year revenue potential (annual occupancy x average daily rate x 365). *Realised yield*: average realised short-let revenue per listing divided by unit price, gross of costs.

Heirstone analysis. Calculations combining published figures are labelled in exhibit sources. They include December uplift and contribution to growth (GTA Table 1), net air passenger flows (GCAA), the two December value estimates, receipts per arrival, the monthly index, fare ratios, December short-let weights and uplifts, gross yields, the Airbnb-visible share of Lagos short-let income (777 x US$1,432 + 581 x US$1,479 + 236 x US$404 = US$2.07m), Marhaba concentration, Benin budgets in US$ and cost per key (FCFA183bn / about 170 keys), distances, the Heirstone typology, the twelve-month test and the Homecoming Benchmark.

Exchange rates. US Treasury reporting rates: GHS 10.4, NGN1,450, KES128.9, MAD9.101, XOF553.75 per US$ at 31 December 2025; GHS 14.65, KES128.85, MAD10.103 at 31 December 2024; NGN1,490 at 30 September 2025. A dollar bought about 29% fewer cedis at 31 December 2025 than a year earlier (the cedi appreciated about 41% against the dollar), so cedi figures from different months are not converted. Lagos prices quoted in naira reflect a currency that has devalued sharply since 2023.

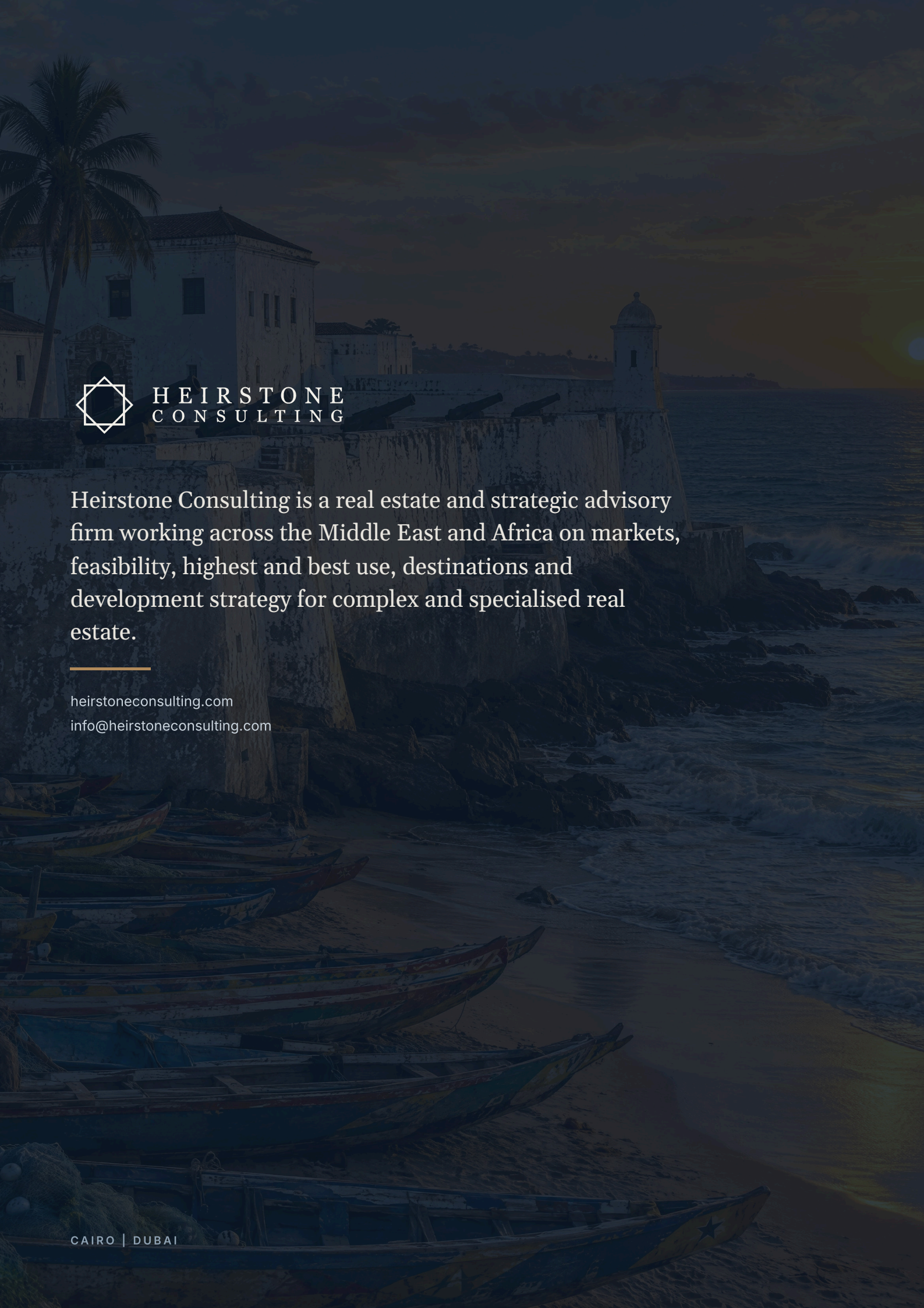
Data cautions. GTA's December survey does not publish its sample size, respondents' residence or length of stay. KAYAK figures are search-price medians, not transaction fares. AirROI and Airbtics differ materially; AirROI annual revenue averages listings not live all year. The Lagos US$71.6m and Calabar 248,000 figures are claims with no published method. AirROI and Lagos short-let figures cover different periods from the Lagos claim. The Marhaba share of annual MRE arrivals mixes years.

Sources, Chapters 1 and 2. Ghana Tourism Authority, Ghana Tourism Report 2025 (June 2026); Ghana Civil Aviation Authority, General Statistics: International 2024 and 2025; UN Africa Renewal (2018); Starr FM (2019); Myjoyonline (2020); AFP via Yahoo News (23 August 2019); Moroccan Ministry of Tourism, key figures 2024; Egyptian Streets citing CAPMAS (2017); Ecofin Agency citing the Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities (2026); Central Bank of Egypt via Enterprise (27 August 2025); Tourism Research Institute, Kenya, Tourism Sector Performance Report 2024 and Tourist Exit Survey 2023; World Bank WDI; Eurostat avia_paexcc (2026); KAYAK route pages (2026); ATTA citing OAG (6 January 2026); BellaNaija (2022); Mondaq (2025); TheCable (2022); Africanews (2023); Ghana Tourism Authority, December in GH visa notice (2024).

Chapters 3 and 4. GTA (2025), pp.25-40; ThisDay (15 February 2025); Nairametrics (20 January and 26 September 2025); AirROI market pages for Accra, Lagos, Lekki, Nairobi, Cape Town, Cape Coast, Dakar, Marrakesh and Cairo, and country pages (12 September 2026); Airbtics, Accra (12 March 2026); Global Property Guide, Egypt, Morocco and South Africa yields (2026); CAHF, Housing Finance in Africa Yearbook 2024 (Ghana, Nigeria, Senegal); The Guardian (Nigeria), 22 December 2025; W Hospitality Group, hotel chain pipelines 2024 and 2026; GTA notices (17 May 2022; 22 December 2024).

Chapters 5 to 7. Government of Benin, Bénin Révélé project sheets 139, 141, 143, 147 and tourism page; benin.bj (Vodun Days 2026); myafroorigins.bj; Government of Benin, Law 2024-31 (2024); Embassy of Benin in the United States (2025); UNESCO World Heritage Centre and Committee (1978); GeoNames; Ghana News Agency (2019); Eko Atlantic; CNN (2013); Cross River State Government (2025); BusinessDay (2026); Myjoyonline (2024); Biennale de Dakar (2023); World Bank WDI; Ghana Immigration Service, Right of Abode; Egyptian Ministry of Housing, Bait El Watan and Your Home in Egypt notices (January and October 2025); Fondation Mohammed V pour la Solidarité, Opération Marhaba 2026 (10 June and 15 September 2026); Hespress FR (September 2025); APA News (6 August 2025); Moroccan Ministry of Tourism (2026); Dakaractu (August 2021); AllAfrica / Le Soleil (22 December 2025); Natural Earth.

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